Wall butterflies and climate change

Climate change sometimes produces unexpected results. For example, in the UK, the life cycle of the wall butterfly has been disrupted by changing climatic conditions. Previously, the butterfly produced two generations every summer. The late-summer adults would mate, the females lay eggs, and the eggs then developed into caterpillars. In September, these caterpillars found sufficient food to grow large and sustain themselves in hibernation through winter. In spring, the caterpillars metamorphosed into pupae, and then became adults. Warmer weather has allowed a third generation to develop in fall, with adults flying as late as mid-October. By the time the third generation caterpillars hatch there is little food, so most starve and die. Scientists call this a “developmental trap” and it is probably responsible for the decline in wall butterflies.

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